shelter was strange in the surroundings we were in that evening, but it was what I needed to do to explain why I'd wanted the party to take place. And why I wanted everyone to be generous when it came to the charity auction. Which they were: and our guests stumped up over £250,000.

We had a fantastic evening. Victoria and I had to call it quits about midnight. Some of the players, and other people who had brought their families along, had already left but there were plenty still enjoying themselves when we went back to the house to get ready for bed and Dubai.

I know the United medical staff weren't all that happy about me going off to Dubai with the rest of the England squad to start our preparations for the World Cup. I think the manager assumed the week would just be a lark and that I'd stand a better chance of being fit if I stayed in Manchester and worked with the trainers at Carrington. I knew that, even when I went off to play for my country, I was still a United player. If the club had really put their foot down I'd have done what they said without thinking twice. Sven wanted me to be with the rest of the players for the two weeks leading up to our first game and Gary Lewin, the England trainer, and Doc Crane, the England doctor, were two of the best in the business. At one stage, the FA offered to take a United medical team along with us. To be honest, it was an argument I wanted other people to have. I didn't think it was right for me to be involved in any dispute. I was ready to go along with whatever decision was made behind the scenes. And that decision, eventually, was that I went.

Early on Monday morning, May 13 2002: lying in bed next to Victoria at home in Sawbridgeworth. Everything in the house was quiet. Somewhere in the distance outside, I could hear the last few people making their way home from the party and climbing into waiting cars. I reached down and touched my left foot: a little sore since Victoria and I had started the dancing in the marquee after dinner. In a few hours we'd be off to the airport. I had eighteen days ahead of me, eighteen days to make sure I'd be right to line up against Sweden on the other side of the world on May 31. I got a little chill feeling deep down at the base of my spine. Excitement? Or dread? Four years ago, I'd been getting ready to head off to the last World Cup. How much had happened since then? 1998 already seemed so long ago: Argentina, a red card and the rest. But, at the same time, it seemed as if the next challenge had stolen up on us in the blink of an eye. Just having the chance to be involved in a World Cup is a dream and a privilege. And every player knows that during the month of that tournament your career, and your life, can change forever. Mine had in France, in the harsh glare of a floodlit evening in Saint-Etienne. I shut my eyes and sank back into the dark. What was waiting for me, and